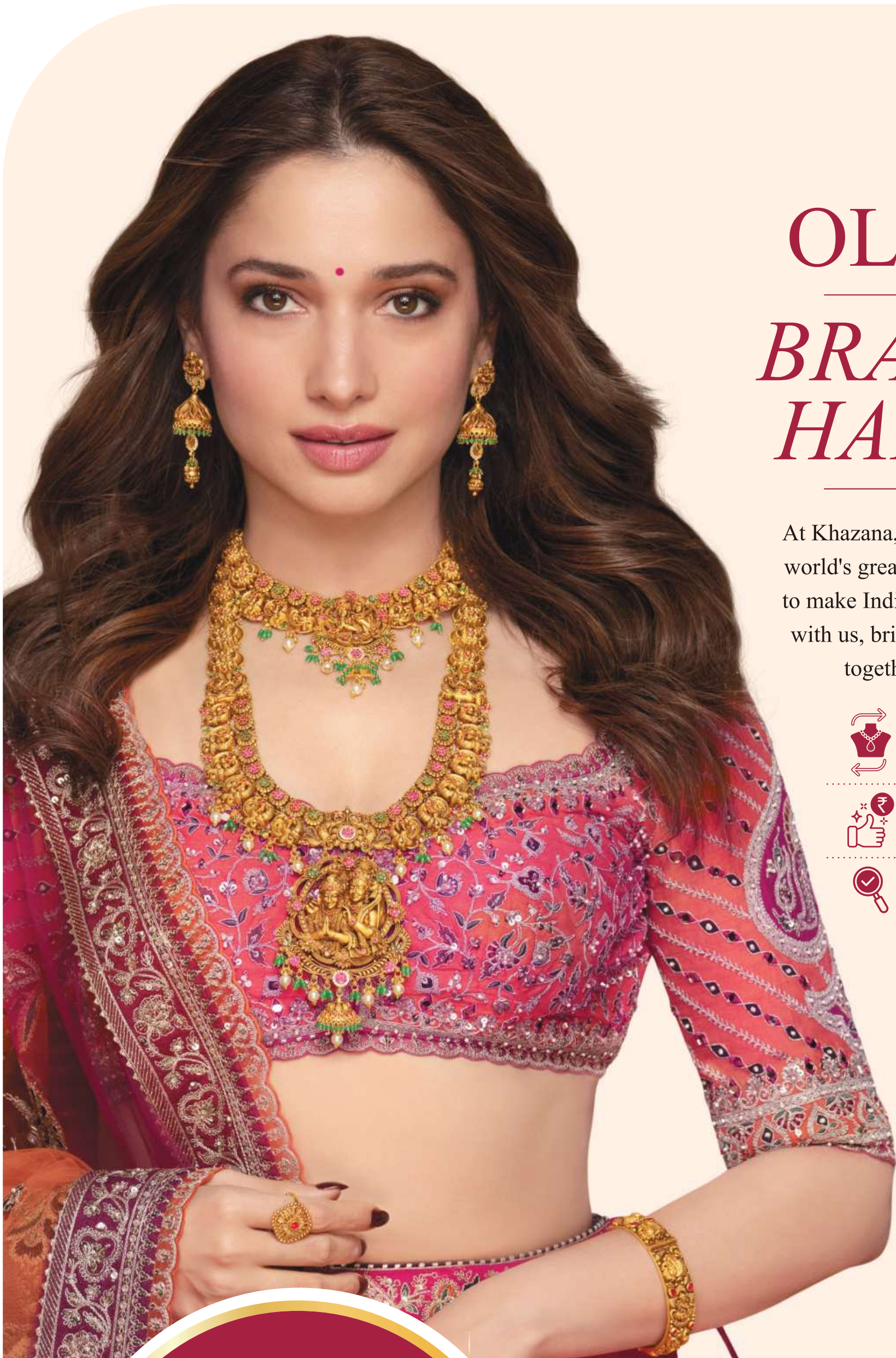




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Beyond the mountains,
Kathmandu pulses
with rituals, reels,
nightlife, and political
hope **P6**

Dawn of the *weeb*

**FULL STORY ON
» PAGE 4**

pick of the week



Sounds of Pride

Sofar Chennai's June show is set to bring together music, community, and a room full of strangers who might just feel like home. In partnership with Sunshine House as the Queer Community Partner, this edition celebrates Pride Month with secret artistes, an intimate venue, and a space open to all. Happening on June 13 at 6.30pm, the venue will be revealed 48 hours before the show. *Tickets are available on sofarsounds.com starting ₹750.*



Versions of you

Somewhere in the multiverse, another version of you is probably thriving, writing poetry, or finally replying to that text. Maybe in Another Universe, an open mic evening invites audiences to explore their "what-ifs" through storytelling, spoken word, and performance. Hosted by Akshara, the event takes place on May 30 from 6.30pm to 8.30pm at the Backyard, Adyar. *Tickets priced at ₹236 on beacons.ai.*



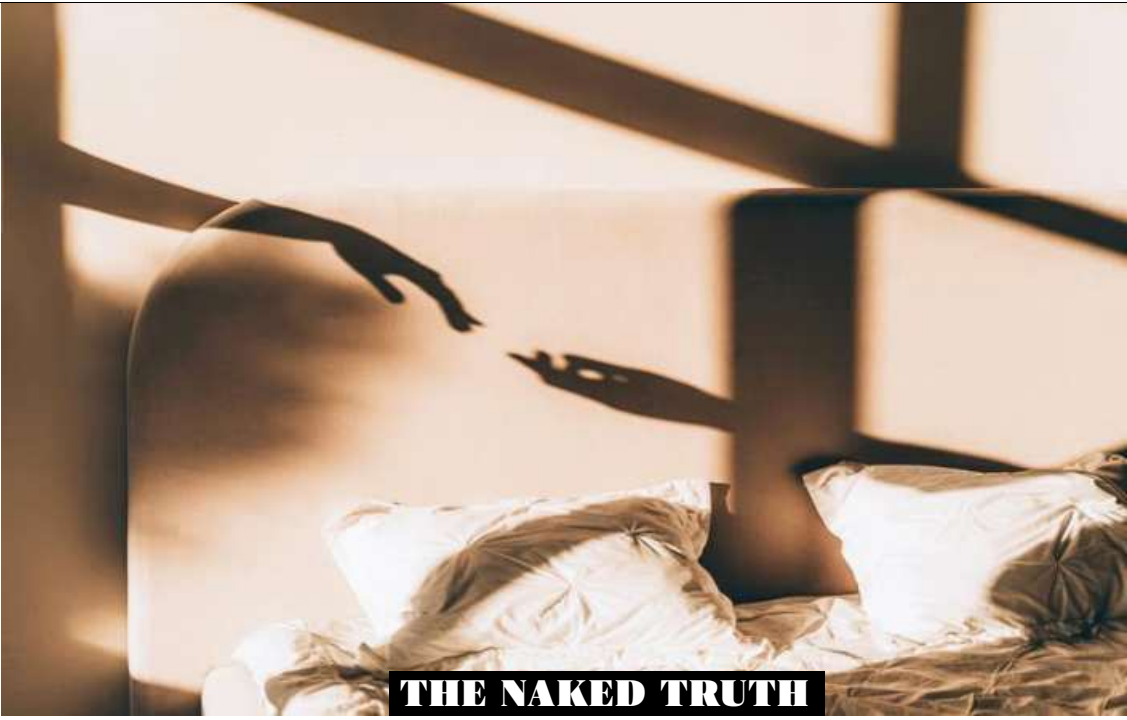
Goal diggers

Calling all women ready to finally kick the ball instead of just cheering from the sidelines. Sisters in Sweat's beginner-friendly football coaching session is back this Saturday with drills, gameplay, and plenty of sweaty fun on the field. No football shoes? No problem — training shoes work just fine. Just bring water, enthusiasm, and your game face. *On May 30 from 8am to 9am at Nexus, Royapettah. Registration on sistersinsweat.com*



What to read next?

Author Yōko Ogawa's haunting novel *The Memory Police* takes centrestage this Sunday as The Love Lit Society hosts a book-club-meets-mock-trial. Expect debates, symbolism spirals, existential meltdowns, and chaotic theories as readers unpack themes of memory, censorship, grief, and disappearance. The session begins at 11am on May 31, at Vinyl & Brew, Alwarpet, with tickets priced at ₹700. *Tickets on kynhood.com*



THE NAKED TRUTH

Barry Rodgers
barry.nathaniel@thehindu.co.in

In modern dating culture, situationships have become nearly impossible to escape. Much like surge pricing or “just checking in” emails, they are everywhere. Most people have probably been in one themselves while insisting to friends they were merely “keeping things casual”. The term began circulating online in the late Noughties and early 2010s, before entering mainstream vocabulary around 2019. Suddenly, the situationship became the official term for relationships that contained all the intimacy of commitment without any of the structural clarity. In fact, Tinder's 2022 Year in Swipe report recorded a 49% increase in users adding ‘situationship’ to their profiles, even while broader studies around Gen Z dating habits continue to show rising emotional fatigue around ambiguous relationships. A communications professional in New Delhi recalls how she entered one during the lockdown in 2020, which formally ended only in 2023. They texted constantly, spoke every day, had date nights twice a week and spent enough time

We've got a situationship

From therapy-speak to decoding attachment styles, modern dating is ripe with emotional vocabulary. So why are situationships still thriving?

together that her friends assumed they were already a couple. “At one point,” she says, “we were discussing each other's parents’ blood pressure medication.” The problem was that every time she attempted to define the relationship, the man would move the goalpost. The first time she brought up commitment, he responded with: “Why don't we get to know each other better? There's no need to rush.” She agreed. A few months later, the conversation returned, then dissolved again. “I knew I was being breadcrumb,” she says now. “But at the time, I convinced myself patience was maturity.”

For the uninitiated, breadcrumbing is when someone gives you just enough attention to keep you hooked, but they never fully commit. Ever since ending things, she says, she has “padded herself up” emotionally. She journals, listens obsessively to American psychotherapist Esther Perel's *Where Should We Begin?* podcast and has read enough relationship psychology books to diagnose attachment styles at dinner parties. “Theoretically, I know exactly what unhealthy dynamics look like,” she says. “But when you're actually inside it, none of that knowledge helps.”

Never before has a generation possessed so much emotional vocabulary. People use terms like

Modern dating still has to contend with situationships; the poster for situationship coaching. GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCK AND SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



“avoidant,” “love bombing,” “breadcrumbing”, and “intermittent reinforcement” with frightening fluency. Podcasts like *Call Her Daddy* and *Where Should We Begin?* have transformed emotional confusion into cultural literacy, while books such as *Attached* by Amir Levine and Rachel Heller became near-essential reading for daters trying to decode emotional inconsistency.

Slipping up
Yet, despite all this information, people continue walking into situationships with astonishing regularity. A Mumbai-based consultant in his early 30s says he finds the popular narrative around situationships rather dishonest. “There's this assumption that men are always the ones perpetuating them,” he says. “Some of us fall hopelessly in love inside them.” He recalls one situationship that began casually enough. “Initially, it's always about the chase,” he says. “Most guys know within two or three months whether this is serious or not. Usually the thrill has an expiry date.” But this one lingered unexpectedly. “She was brilliant. Very funny. We had incredible intimacy. I genuinely loved spending time with her.” The complication, however,

was that she continued seeing other people and had been transparent about it from the beginning. “She never lied to me,” he says. “That's the worst part because technically she did everything right.” He laughs before adding, “Nothing equips you for the emotional windfall of a situationship.” Mumbai-based The Intimacy Curator, an intimacy and kink platform that organises community events around modern relationships, recently introduced situationship coaching (for individuals above 21) in early May after noticing how frequently emotionally undefined relationships were showing up in modern dating. Founder Aili Seghetti says the offering emerged after they noticed a gap in how people discussed contemporary relationships. “Situationships aren't a passing trend anymore,” says Aili. “They've become a dominant relationship structure, especially among urban millennials and Gen Z, but most people still treat them like a joke.” What surprised her most, however, was how gendered many of the concerns were. “Heterosexual men were usually approaching me wanting to find women open to situationships,” they say. “Heterosexual and bisexual women, as well as gay men, were more likely to ask how to protect themselves from falling into one, or how to deepen an existing situationship.” Since launching the service through Instagram, Aili says they have received nearly 100 enquiries in just three weeks, largely from the metros. Clients typically undergo multiple one-on-one sessions focussed on building action plans around boundaries, communication and emotional clarity. Perhaps the real irony of the situationship era is this: we are arguably the most emotionally articulate generation in history, yet not necessarily the most emotionally evolved.

A fortnightly guide to love in the age of bare minimum.

(Clockwise from right) An illustration in *Asamo, is that you?*; sun-dried eel; black sesame lentils, seasonal vegetable curry, and tuber curry; Chef Ahmedaki Laloo; and Canato Jimo. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Nidhi Adlakha
nidhi.adlakha@thehindu.co.in

In *Asamo, is that you?* authors Canato Jimo and Ogin Nayam tell the story of Yumum, a young girl looking for her companion, Asamo, in the dark. A tale that explores themes of navigating fear, it also delicately depicts a series of monsters inspired by traditional lore and myths from Northeast India. This, by way of stunning illustrations that “are not in your face,” says Canato, art director and award-winning picture book maker. Even *Snip* (a wordless book on two mischievous siblings who cut their own hair) was distinctly set in Nagaland but this setting does not overtake the story. “As storytellers and artists it is easy to alienate our stories with esoteric cultural nuances, and I try to ensure a balance is maintained to make stories relatable, yet not devoid of the spaces they are coming from,” adds the artist, who will be sharing similar insights on art, diversity, folklore, and food at an event organised by *The Hindu Lit for Life Unplugged* in Chennai next weekend. Organised in collaboration with city-based Chef Chindi Vardarajulu, the event will feature Canato in conversation with Rosella Stephen, editor, *The Hindu Sunday Magazine*, on June 5. This will be followed by a five course menu, on June 6 and 7, by Chef Ahmedaki Laloo from Shillong, as a part of Zhouyu Hosts, a culinary series that will bring chefs from across India and Asia to Chennai. “People tend to have a narrow lens while looking at this part of the country,” says Canato, who hails from Nagaland. “In storytelling, it isn't so much about merely making themes contemporary as it is about



The taste of belonging

At Lit for Life Unplugged x Zhouyu Hosts, Naga illustrator Canato Jimo will speak about creativity in a world of AI, followed by Ahmedaki Laloo's five course menu that tells the story of Meghalaya

authentic, everyday life experiences and lived realities. They add to the story, which ultimately is the hero of any book,” he shares. **Art and AI** Canato is also looking forward to discussing how traditional illustration skills still hold strong

despite the influx of AI in the art world. “It is distressing to see so much out there being created with a prompt and a click, specifically in the visual space, and with no ethical regard. But despite it all, I positively hold on to the opinion that traditional illustration is alive and well, and won't be phasing out



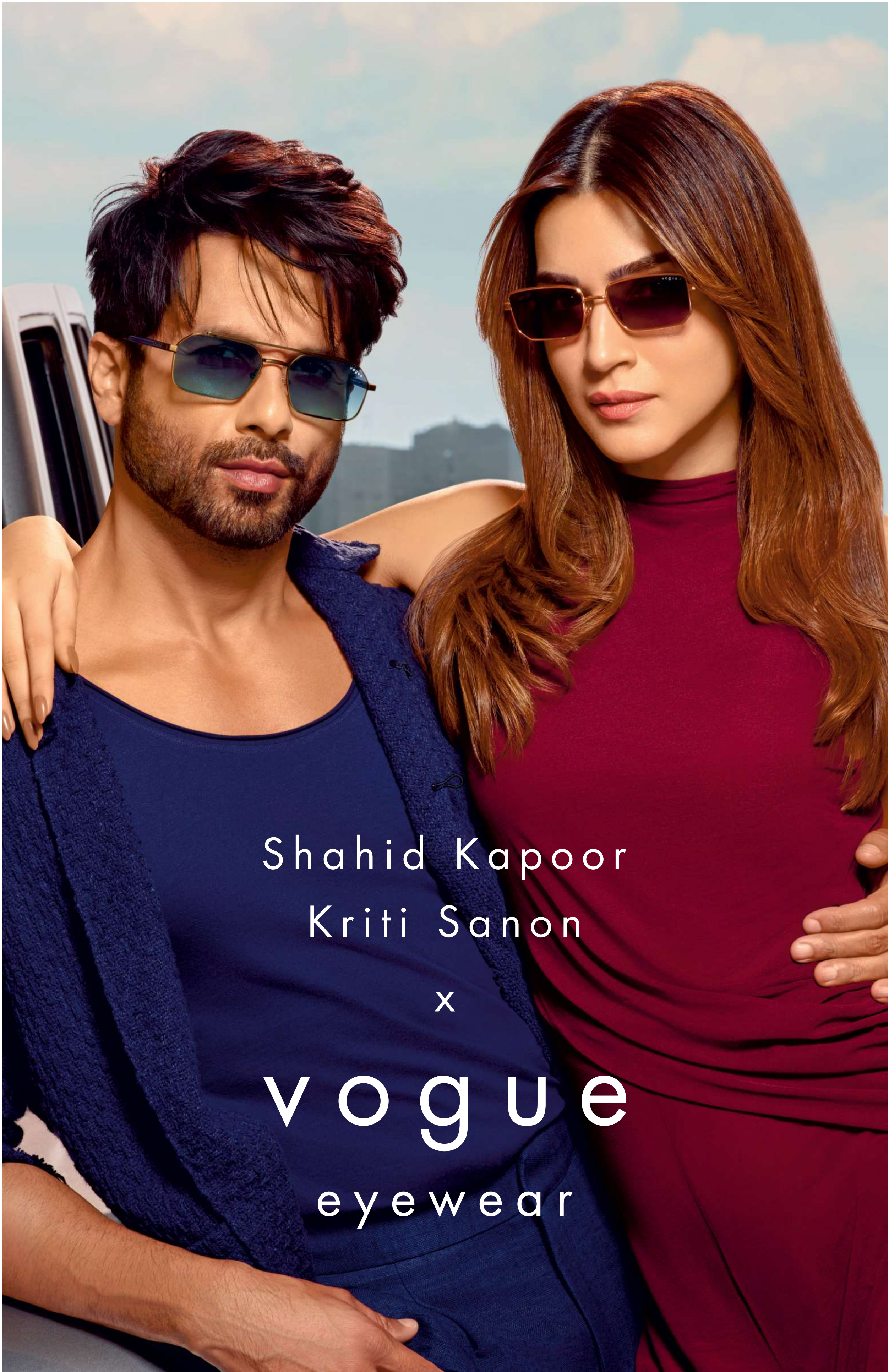
anytime soon. If anything, it should push us illustrators out of our mediocrity, make our visual voice even more distinct and strong,” he says. After moving out of Nagaland and living in other Indian cities, Canato realised how he, like most others, was “cautious and even embarrassed” about the food he grew up eating. “Naga food can be intense in its preparation and flavour, and we end up being very self conscious in cooking and sharing our food. In some way, it plays with our psyche of acceptance and belonging,” he shares. Having said that, Canato is now overcoming this and is proud of “my food”. “I am no longer apologetic about my food, and take ownership of it. Many stores across Indian cities now sell Naga produce such as herbs, veggies, and aromatics, which is very heartening. I also see many restaurants with locals enjoying Naga food,” says Canato who has rekindled his love for food by often cooking traditional delicacies such as rusep (assorted veggies in bamboo shoot),

perilla with dried mushrooms, and pork, for friends.

Meghalaya on a plate
While Canato plans to dig into his childhood culinary memories at the talk, Chef Ahmedaki – founder of A'Origins, a boutique dining experience in Shillong – looks forward to introducing Chennai to Meghalaya by way of a five-course meal. “The menu will comprise produce-centric dishes, and spotlight our cooking techniques, and indigenous ingredients,” she says. The latter includes Lakadong turmeric, black pepper, bay leaf, peppercorns, and chillies: ingredients that she will be bringing to the city. “We are going to bring 80% of the ingredients needed for the pop-up. These include foraged mushrooms, black sesame, flattened rice, fermented soy bean, and fermented bamboo shoot,” says Ahmedaki. With options for vegetarian and non-vegetarian dishes in every course, the highlights include charred foraged mushroom with smoked black sesame jus and flattened rice, grilled chicken marinated in bamboo shoot, grilled pork skewers, seasonal greens tempura with roselle dust, and more. The fourth course, in particular, features a thali with vegetables, broths, pickles, and salads. “This is all about blending food, memory, and region,” says Chindi, who is excited to see Zhouyu Hosts taking off. “I have been bringing my memories of food, my experiences across South East Asia, at all my restaurants. But I wanted to showcase this connection with food across Asia and beyond,” says the chef.

The Hindu Lit For Life Unplugged x Zhouyu Hosts is on June 5, from 6.30pm to 7.30pm. Entry is free, but seats are limited, so book ahead on 9363036446. The pop-up, priced at ₹3,150 per person, is on June 5 (only dinner), 6 and 7 for lunch and dinner, at Zhouyu Alwarpet. For reservations, call 9363036446.





LEGACY
ANTHEMS
LIVE AT
THE ANIME
AWARDS

Beyond the trophies, this year's Crunchyroll Anime Awards leaned heavily into anime nostalgia and legacy, with three musical performances honouring some of the medium's most defining theme songs and franchises.



Dawn of the
weeb

THE CASE FOR ANIME

Celebrities and industry leaders in attendance at the Anime Awards 2026 tell us why anime continues to resonate across cultures, and why newcomers should take the leap of faith:



"Anime inspires a lot of things in my life. *Naruto* makes me never give up and then I can be where I am right now... If you're willing to give it a try, anime will definitely be better than what you thought. When you get into it, you can't stop."

Bambam,
THAI K-POP ARTISTE



"I love how anime can challenge conventional thought and methodology and just allow your brain to go, 'Whoa, well, what if that is the truth or could be the truth?' It's just a really cool thing."

Winston Duke,
HOLLYWOOD ACTOR



"I think the artistry, the visuals, the colourfulness, the larger-than-life characters [in anime], all have a lot in common with Indian cinema... Anime is for everyone. Anime is a medium that features every genre. So there is a show for everybody. Once you watch the first, you're going to fall in love."

Rahul Purini,
PRESIDENT AND
CEO,
CRUNCHYROLL



Ayaan Paul Chowdhury
ayaan.paul@thehindu.co.in

Two years ago, Rashmika Mandanna became the first Indian actor invited to present at the Crunchyroll Anime Awards, an annual show organised by the anime streaming giant to honour the best in Japanese animation released during the previous year. The ceremony returned for its 10th anniversary celebration this year with presenters including The Weeknd, Winston Duke, Wu-Tang Clan's RZA, and Thai K-pop stars BamBam and TEN. Last weekend, Rashmika joined that assorted roster of high-profile weeb, returning to present once more at the Grand Prince Hotel Shin Takanawa in Tokyo.

As one of the most outspoken celebrity otakus (or fans) from India, Rashmika's return to Tokyo seems to centre on the nostalgia of fandom coming full circle. "Once upon a time, I opened a random channel after a rough day and got hooked on to something like an anime – that was my first introduction," she says. "Getting the chance to meet the creators and witnessing the reason for the anime community to be what it is today was definitely something I never thought would be possible. I'm really grateful. It's very surreal and special, and I just feel like I've done something right."

The anime fandom in India has always possessed a peculiar generational texture that people outside the country rarely understand. Long before Crunchyroll was ever a thing, anime circulated through 480p rips on YouTube, dubbed CDs from grey-market electronics stores, and inconsistent cable broadcasts. Japanese entertainment channel Animax was central to that nostalgic ecosystem through the Noughties because it introduced



Indian otakus to shows such as *Naruto: Shippuden* and *Fullmetal Alchemist* through badly timed cable TV runs. Anime was often that weird something that you absolutely *did not* mention out loud unless somebody else started first, since public admission of affection usually invited particularly pronounced looks of derision, and/or snarky remarks about "cartoons".

Rashmika believes that the cultural mood has shifted. "I think the generation is a lot more comfortable with voicing out what we really like and what our interests are, and that's a good start," she says. "I've always been very vocal about loving anime because I pretty much grew up watching it. Everyone thinks it's all just visual, but there's also a lot of in-depth emotional storytelling and layering, and that's what gets me hooked on watching something".

Spurred by inspiration

The shonen classic *Naruto: Shippuden* was foundational to her attachment. "I feel like somewhere deep down, his [Naruto's] characteristic trait of never giving up has somehow always been subconsciously embedded in me. So it feels like never giving up has become my motto in life, and that's why I'm able to do what I'm able to do today." Asked whether anime changed the way she thinks about acting and expression, she immediately focuses on animation's ability to externalise interior emotion. "In live-action, we're portrayed how we are to be portrayed from a director's lens. Whereas in animation, I feel like you witness and you understand exactly what they're feeling," she says. "Anime has the ability to make you feel like you have a stone in your throat. It can really make you feel emotional because of the small nuances that they've gotten right only through animation."

Her latest mission: trying to convert her husband and fellow Telugu star Vijay Deverakonda into a weeb. "I have suggested *Naruto: Shippuden*, or perhaps *Haikyuu!!* because he really loves playing volleyball. But I'll get him there eventually."

Long-running Japanese rock band Porno Graffitti performed 'The Day' and 'The Revo' from *My Hero Academia*, reviving two of the superhero anime's most recognisable theme songs.

(Left) Influential alt-rock band Asian Kung-Fu Generation performed 'Re:Re.' from *ERASED* and 'Haruka Kanata' from *Naruto*, revisiting two songs that helped define 2000s anime fandom outside Japan.

(Right) Veteran anisong singer Yoko Takahashi performed 'A Cruel Angel's Thesis' from Neon Genesis Evangelion as part of the franchise's 30th anniversary celebration.

Japanese singer-actor Dean Fujioka performed 'History Maker', the soaring figure-skating anthem from *Yuri on Ice*, revisiting the song that accompanied one of anime's defining modern sports dramas.



Though *My Hero Academia* took home the coveted top prize of Anime of the Year at this year's awards, here's how we personally ranked the nominees that defined anime's wildly varied year in television.



1. The Summer Hikaru Died

Watching *The Summer Hikaru Died* felt like sharing a perverse secret. This is a rural horror story about a boy who returns from the mountains changed, and the friend who loves him anyway, and it's the year's clearest proof that the genre works best when unhurried.

THE HINDU
RANKS
ANIME OF
THE YEAR
NOMINEES
2026



2. The Apothecary Diaries Season 2

A stunning courtly mystery series centred on a sharp-eyed apothecary navigating power dynamics in an imperial palace, Toho Animation and OLM sustain their commitment to this exquisite procedural drama and let method dictate momentum.

3. Gachiakuta

For once, "trashcore shonen" isn't an insult. Emerging in the wake of *Bones*' freshly concluded *My Hero Academia* run, *Gachiakuta* is a study of resisting oppression that follows a boy exiled to a landfill underworld, where discarded objects and waste become the tools of liberation for the oppressed.

4. Takopi's Original Sin

This deceptively cute science-fiction tragedy is about an alien sent to spread happiness on Earth who meets a child facing bullying and abuse, but it's really a compact study of how adults, institutions, and classmates collectively fail a girl until death feels like her only exit.



6. My Hero Academia: Final Season

My Hero Academia's farewell season carried the wistful pride of a franchise that had matured in real time with its fans, and *Bones* closed its long-running mythos with ceremonial care.



The writer was in Japan at the invitation of Crunchyroll.

S Poorvaja

poorvaja.sundar@thehindu.co.in

As invitees, attendees and brand ambassadors sashay down the red carpet at La Croisette, there is no other fashion moment that India eagerly awaits quite as much as Aishwarya Rai Bachchan's annual appearance at the Cannes Film Festival.

This year, Aishwarya made her first appearance towards the end of the 79th edition of the festival. She stepped out on the red carpet in an electric blue, sparkly Amit Aggarwal gown, making heads turn. She followed this up with two more appearances, in a white Cheney Chan tuxedo with a dramatic, feather boa and a delicate, blush Sophie Couture gown worn with a long, sheer cape.

She also donned a pale pink strapless Fjolla Nila gown, with a feather boa for an evening at the film festival.

She absolutely can

At Cannes, Aishwarya Rai made heads turn in an electric blue Amit Aggarwal gown, followed by blush pinks and feather boas. Stylist and designer Mohit Rai takes us behind the scenes

At the helm of Aishwarya's wardrobe this year was stylist Mohit Rai. "Aishwarya is extremely collaborative. Every detail is discussed with her and she is always open to discuss further, down to a T; to ensure that the final look is seamless," he says, of working with the star.

Designer choices

Mohit describes the run up to the festival as months of mood-boarding, ideation and conceptualisation. "All of it felt extremely surreal. It only hit me when the clothes actually started coming in and we went in for our first fitting," he says.

With 3D embellishments and embroidery, Amit Aggarwal's fitted, fishtail gown, Luminara, that Aishwarya made a splash on the red carpet in, took nearly 1,500 hours to craft. The handwork went into crystalline linear embellishments across the gown, held together through an intricate lattice structure, creating an effect of illuminated pathways across the

body. "The commitment to colour, craftsmanship and Indian artistry on a global platform is something only Aishwarya has made time and again," Mohit says, on Aishwarya's decision to go with an Indian designer for her first look.

Every part of the blue gown, he adds, was constructed to respond to illumination, and to look different under different lighting



conditions. On the red carpet outdoors, and under camera flashes, the gown sparkled.

"The Sophie Couture gown had this underlying femininity through the choices of fabric and silhouette. Cheney on the other hand – was one whose proportions felt interesting. The cinched waist along with the shoulders felt bold in a refreshing way," Mohit explains.

When asked if he felt any pressure styling Aishwarya for the first time for her much awaited annual Cannes appearance, the stylist emphasises on wanting each look to have a strong point of view, and an individuality of its own. "It was all about understanding that we were working with – an extraordinary person at a platform that is a pinnacle of cinema and fashion. Hence there was so much more that went into the ideation and conceptualisation to ensure that the end result reflected it," he adds.



Aishwarya Rai at Cannes; and (inset) Mohit Rai. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Just play

Why the 1983 World Cup-winning captain Kapil Dev believes that India should look beyond cricket

Srinivasa Ramanujam
srinivasa.r@thehindu.co.in

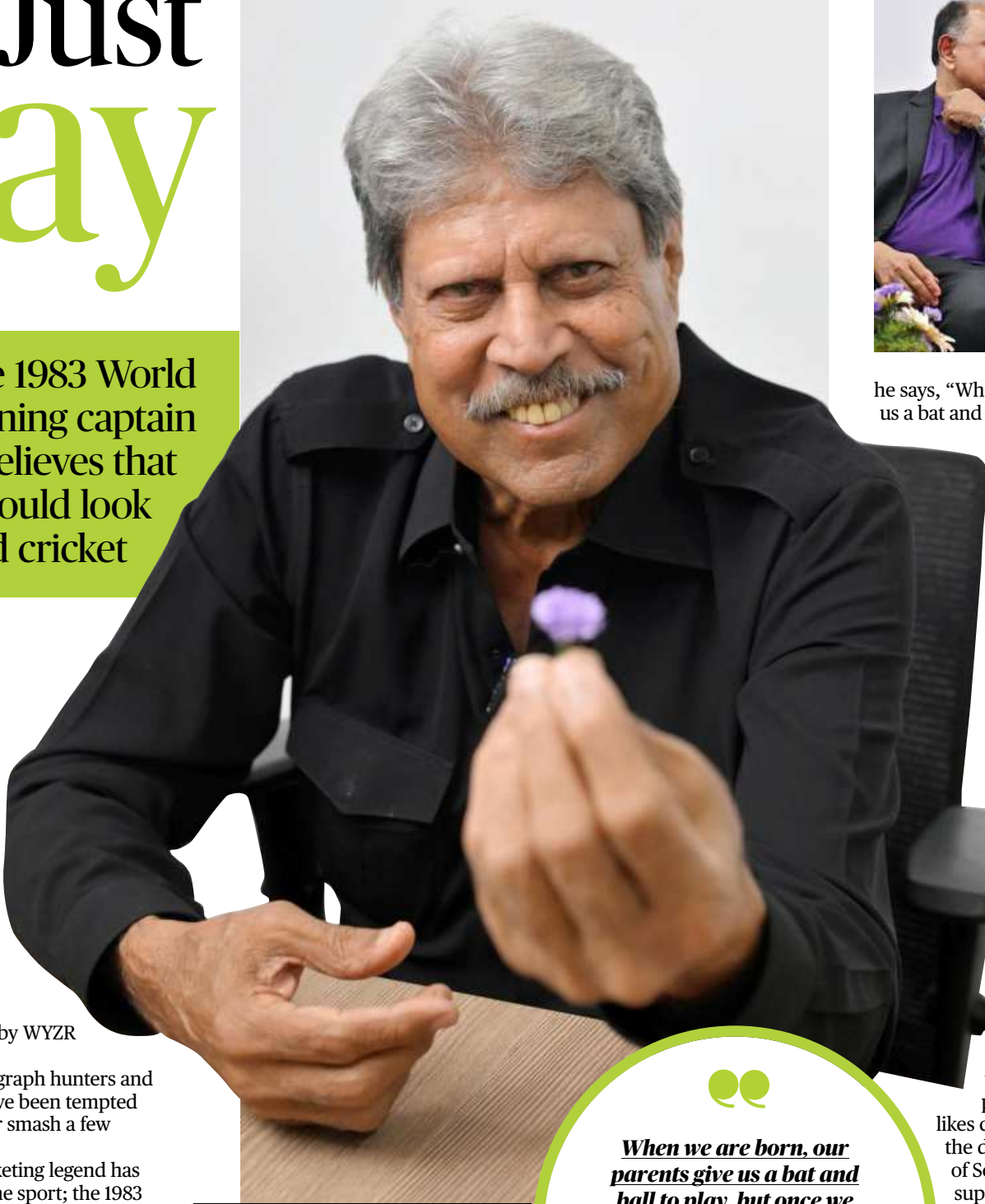
Kapil Dev quickly glances at the bat and ball placed at the entrance of the Madras Management Association's auditorium. They are a photo prop – for the members attending the launch of popular banker Shyam Srinivasan's latest book, *Better Never Stops*, a part-memoir, part-practical leadership primer published by WYZR Books (₹495).

If not for the teeming autograph hunters and selfie seekers, Kapil might have been tempted to bowl a couple of yorkers or smash a few sixes.

The 67-year-old lanky cricketing legend has seen the highest of highs in the sport; the 1983 World Cup win being the peak. He is currently associated with another sport – golf – which he plays equally passionately.

But deep down, Kapil remains the boy who once loved hitting the grounds of Chandigarh with a bat and ball in hand.

"People like us... we know only thing: how to play. If we had it our way, we would be playing some kind of sport from childhood till death,"



To watch video interview, scan QR code

When we are born, our parents give us a bat and ball to play, but once we turn six or seven, they replace it with a pencil to concentrate on education

KAPIL DEV
Cricketer



Cricket legend Kapil Dev; (left) with author Shyam Srinivasan.
JOHAN SATHYADAS, AND VELANKANNI RAJ B

The Kapil way

On Chennai:

I feel this is my favourite city. It is hot, but it's a beautiful place. And, I love the food here.

On leadership:

Your surroundings make you a leader. I try to learn something from everyone I meet – right from a rickshaw wallah I meet on the road to my driver.

On his biggest learning:

The 1983 World Cup win taught me to never ever give up.

he says, "When we are born, our parents give us a bat and ball to play, but once we turn six or seven, they replace it with a pencil to concentrate on education."

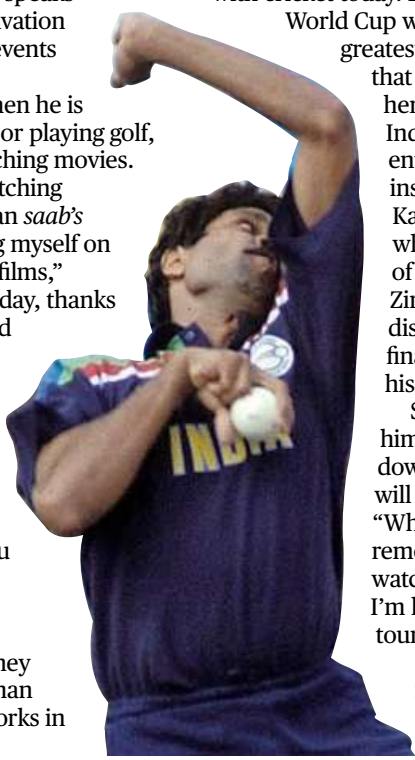
A huge cheerleader for sporting activities, Kapil is peeved about India's obsession with cricket. "I'm saying this despite being a cricketer myself and fully knowing the love and affection it fetched me," he smiles, "As a nation, we give 99% to cricket. It's unfair. Other sports should also get recognition...only then will the nation grow."

Kapil is a content sportsman today, even as he speaks words of motivation at corporate events and sporting functions. When he is not travelling or playing golf, he enjoys watching movies.

"I grew up watching Amitabh Bachchan *saab's* films and styling myself on his looks in the films," recalls Kapil. Today, thanks to technology and the advent of OTT platforms, Kapil

likes catching up on the dubbed versions of South Indian superhits too.

"*Baahubali* was great, and I love watching Allu Arjun's films too," says Kapil, mimicking the trademark *Pushpa* beard-stroke swagger, "They make some people larger than life, but that's how cinema works in this part of the world."



Cricket, however, is never entirely out of his life – despite his own admission that he watches only "5% of the matches today". Like most followers of IPL 2026, Kapil too is full of praise for young sensation, Vaibhav Suryavanshi. "At the moment, he is a special talent, without doubt. But we have to give him time. He is very young and does not know anything other than cricket. Once he gets to know more about life, things might be different."

Blast from the past

Kapil can be credited for the obsession India has with cricket today. Leading India, the historic World Cup win in 1983 is considered the greatest triumph of the underdog

that cricket has ever seen, heralding a young generation of Indian cricket players and enthusiasts. Apart from instilling self belief in the team, Kapil's crucial batting knock when they were on the verge of elimination (175 against Zimbabwe) and iconic catch (to dismiss Viv Richards in the final) remains the highlight of his glittering career.

So, what was he telling himself when the chips were down? "It's a story other people will tell better than me," he says, "When you are in it, you don't remember it as vividly as people watching it. It was my day, and I'm happy that I won the tournament for India."

Is there a life lesson he has for people? "Never ever give up. The moment you give up, you are dead."

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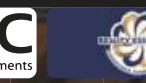
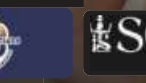
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Shonali Muthalaly
shonali.m@thehindu.co.in

I did not expect to lock eyes with a living goddess in Nepal. But Kathmandu pulsates with prayer, ritual and surprises, despite its reputation as a party stop en route to the mountains. On Everest Day, as climbers and summit counts dominate the conversation, it feels like a good time to look away from the mountain straining under record crowds, and struggling to survive its own popularity. Instead, I settle in Kathmandu to explore the richness of the valleys below.

From Thamel, boisterous with nightclubs, hiking stores and fit climbers in ‘Annapoorna Base Camp’ T-shirts, I head to historic Durbar Square, weaving between believers, TikTokers and tourists.

Following a prayerful, curious queue, I enter Kumari Ghar and look up at three intricately carved wooden windows. A hush falls when she appears in the central window, a four-year-old draped in deep red and gold, her kohl-rimmed eyes fixed on the crowds below. The spell breaks when she steps away, and the influencers move in for their reels, despite a handwritten notice saying ‘No TikTok’ on the wall.

As I step out, a young band of Nepalis in faded jeans and leather jackets choreograph a dance reel, while beside them devotees bow their heads to a fierce, ancient Kaal Bhairav shrine carved out of stone.

In Nepal, the sacred remains woven into everyday life.

Country in transition

I’m in Kathmandu for the launch of Moxy, a hotel opening that offers a glimpse into a country in transition.

Nepal has drawn curious visitors for decades, including thousands of hippies who gathered at Kathmandu’s ‘Freak Street’ seeking spirituality, travel and counterculture in the 1960s and ‘70s. I quickly understand why, as I first engage with the modern city’s chic Himalayan Java cafes, designer boutiques and nightclubs, then discover Patan’s hidden courtyard shrines, learn about Bhaktapur’s tantric goddesses in an old antique store and sit pillion behind a speedy woman InDrive biker on a highway in the pouring rain to explore Barahi Ajima Shakti Peeth.

We wait for the downpour to slow down at a falcha, one of the many century old communal rest platforms thoughtfully set across Nepal, where elderly locals now gather to knit and gossip. In a cinematic drizzle, we finally enter the temple, dedicated to one of the eight powerful goddesses believed to protect Bhaktapur where cultural advocate and historian Rushel Shilpakar shows me the city plan, drawn like a mandala, on his iPad before we set out on a four-hour walk through the town, pausing only for juju dhau, sweet, creamy yoghurt



Nepal, beyond Everest

Often treated as a stopover on the way to the summit, Kathmandu is emerging as a destination in its own right, blending living traditions, youthful optimism and a renewed sense of possibility under young rapper-turned-Prime Minister, Balen Shah

made with rich buffalo milk and set in clay pots.

I wander through Bhaktapur and Patan’s alleys, watching tailors, hawkers and vegetable vendors work from century-old buildings, framed by museum quality wood carvings and artwork.

Moxy Kathmandu unconsciously echoes this theme, with its Labubu-rimmed mirror for #FitChecks, and ‘Yoxy,’ a massive paper mache yak in the lobby made by local artists and covered in Devanagari script, set beside prayer flags and Buddhist



symbols.

The hotel’s planned launch in October 2025 was paused when Nepal’s Gen Z protests broke out in early September. The youth-led protests, which escalated rapidly, reshaped Nepal’s politics, and slowed down tourism. Subarna Thapa, affectionately hailed as ‘Captain’ at Moxy Kathmandu says they finally did a soft launch in December, at an occupancy of about 22%.

Despite tensions in West Asia affecting air travel this year, Subarna says there has been a steady rise in tourists since then, with April seeing 55% occupancy at the



hotel, buoyed by the general sense of hope in the country as former rapper and mayor, Balendra Shah, popularly known as Balen, took over as the country’s youngest Prime Minister.

The Balen effect

The optimism is evident at Moxy’s launch party, vibrant with Kathmandu’s glamorous creative set, who play beer pong and take Polaroids by the pool, bobbing with blow-up pink flamingoes as the DJ plays Baby Shark. Digital creator Parakram Rana talks about how the country “now has a golden opportunity to make a difference”. He adds, “Young people are now more politically aware, and eager to participate”.

The next morning, on a scenic hike up to Nagi Gompa, a Buddhist monastery swathed in wildflowers, our guide Prashan Poudyal echoes

Check in with a cocktail and a yak

Moxy Hotels in Kathmandu aims to connect travellers with the city, instead of just cocooning them. When you check into the hotel set in Durbarmarg, close to the action of Thamel, the desk provides cocktails, suggestions for hikes and VIP passes to the city’s top nightclubs, including moody Purple Haze with high energy local bands, Nova (which calls itself Asia’s biggest nightclub) and Supperclub boasting ‘dim sum and disco’.

The lobby, which thuds with music all day and night, offers a bar that fuels guests with coffee, smoothies or cocktails. There is also an oversized teddy bear on offer if you feel like company. Communal spaces encourage travellers to connect, offering the energy of backpacker hostels, with a luxe setting. There are 101 guestrooms, and if you get lucky, there will be a small, comfortably pink, woollen yak at your bedside. Join the city’s smart set at the rooftop bar where you can get a glass of wine, fiery Nepali choila, with buff tempered in mustard oil and timur, then served with crunchy beaten rice, and a spectacular view.

this idea, while helping us put together a playlist of Balen’s greatest hits. (Queue up ‘Balidan’ on systemic corruption and fan favourite ‘Aam Nepali Buwaa’ about working class struggles on your Spotify playlist). “The Prime Minister is my age,” he smiles, “We finally have someone who thinks young.”

Explaining how there is more to Nepal than just hiking, Sunil Sharma, officiating director - Nepal Tourism Board says the country has the potential to be a destination for safaris with Chitwan, as well as wellness and weddings. “Look at the border towns from West Bengal, as infrastructure improves so does tourism. That stretch is full of hotels now,” he says, adding that they expect more global brands to open in Nepal this year.

Fortunately, what makes Nepal so special is so ingrained in the fabric of everyday life that it is unlikely to change. In Patan, I wake up in the mornings and head out for freshly fried sel rotis, then sit barefoot and cross legged among chanting monks at the statuesque 12th-Century Hiranya Varna Mahavihar.

A homecoming

At night, I join Rabin Gurung at Bitters & Co, a stylish cocktail bar in Kathmandu that highlights local ingredients like sea buckthorn, fermented leafy greens and pleasantly numbing timur peppers. Under a lush indoor tree which the bar hugs, reminiscent of community falchas, we snack on spicy Wai Wai sadeko and knock back Titora shooters, made with dry fruit hog plum, both offering an addictive ‘chatpata’ kick of complex sweet, sour and salty flavours.

Explaining why he returned to Nepal, after years in Hong Kong, Rabin says, “This is home. We have a living goddess. We have heritage. If you want to see harmony in chaos come to Nepal. There is magic here.” And now, there is optimism too.

The writer was in Nepal at the invitation of Moxy Kathmandu.

The salt route

Kathmandu-based restaurateur Vivek Man Sherchan is bringing Thakali cuisine, shaped by Himalayan trade routes and local ingredients, to Gurugram through Jimbu Thakali

Garima Verma

Nepal’s culinary landscape – synonymous with momos and daal-bhaat – is being shaped by local ingredients and the flavours of Thakali cuisine.

Often considered the richest ethno-linguistic group of Nepal, Thakalis hail from Thak-sat-se or the Thak Khola region in the Kali Gandaki River valley of the Mustang District in north-central Nepal.

Bringing the cuisine to India is Kathmandu-based Vivek Man Sherchan, an engineer-turned-entrepreneur Thakali who operates Jimbu Thakali, a chain of restaurants in Nepal. Its first Indian outlet will open soon at M3M IFC, Sector 66, Gurugram. He says, “Delhi-NCR might have many places serving Nepali food, but we wanted to bring in authentic Thakali flavours which go beyond stereotypes.”

Historic trail

In his book *The Thakali: A Himalayan Ethnography*, published in 1998, Danish scholar Michael



Vinding notes how the 1855-56 Nepal-Tibet war proved to be the harbinger of prosperity for Thakalis, who make up 1% of the country’s population. Their support as soldiers and translators for Nepalese forces under Prime Minister Jung Bahadur Rana was rewarded with multiple business opportunities in salt trade, mining,



import-export of animals, food items, spices, and as customs collectors. Michael points out, in 1927 the government abolished the old customs collecting system, including the monopoly on the trade of salt. As a result, the community not only migrated from Mustang to the southern regions for better prospects, it also took to

animal husbandry, agriculture, and established hotels and restaurants.

The culinary exchanges over these trade routes were instrumental in developing its cuisine, blending Himalayan ingredients with salt-route spices and Tibetan influences.

The Himalayan influence is reflected well in the use of local staples like buckwheat, millets, jimbu (a herb belonging to the onion/garlic family), timur (Sichuan or Nepali pepper), sukuti (dried meat), gundruk (fermented leafy greens) and sinki (fermented radish roots). Through the old trade routes, Thakalis were introduced to Indian spices like turmeric, cumin, ginger, and fenugreek.

From mom’s kitchen

At the Tantal branch of his Jimbu Thakali restaurants in Kathmandu,

(Clockwise from left) The landscape of Mustang; vegetarian Thakali thali with ghoken (buckwheat pancakes); Vivek Man Sherchan, owner of Jimbu Thakali; and the indigenous architecture of the Newaris. GARIMA VERMA

Vivek guides the guests through the sweet, sour, spicy, frugal, and rich components of a Thakali meal.

It starts with traditional snack from Mustang kanchemba (buckwheat fries), and jimbu-tempered potatoes. “The aim was to bring authentic Thakali – home-cooked, traditional, comfort food – to our guests. Hence, my mother (Prabha Sherchan) played an important part in finalising all the recipes and the menus. Everyone says that her ladle is exceptional,” says Vivek, who started with a restaurant in 2016 and has expanded to four now – three in Kathmandu and one in Patan. For his Delhi restaurant, he wanted a Durbar Square-like setting, showcasing Newari woodwork and the indigenous architecture of the Newaris, the primary residents of Kathmandu valley.

Vivek is confident that Thakali



flavours will be well-received in Delhi. “It will not be a completely unfamiliar palate as there are a lot of similarities between Indian and Nepali food when it comes to spices and produce,” he says. “But the slow cooking methods, especially our daal, and ingredients like jimbu, timur, and phapar (buckwheat) define Thakali food.”

In a traditional Thakali meal, daalbhat (lentils and rice), tarkari (vegetables), achaar (pickles), gundruk (fermented greens), sekuwa (grilled meat), masu (meat curry), make for the key dishes. Dhido, a thick buckwheat or millet porridge, and ghoken (buckwheat pancakes), mixed with home-made aromatic ghee are an integral part of it. Most of the dishes are slow-cooked, lightly tempered, and layered with flavours. In spices, timur from the North, and jimbu from the higher Himalayas stand out.

Apart from these, Jimbu Thakali in Gurugram, will also serve lesser-known Nepali delicacies from other communities. Their ‘choila wings’ are made with traditional Newari spices and mustard oil. Mutton Sukuti is a traditional Nepali delicacy made from dried, smoked goat meat. Through the restaurant, Vivek intends to pay ode to the once seasonal food business of Thakalis that helped them to later diversify and become big players in Nepal’s hospitality industry.

Thakali cuisine is not just a reflection of the community’s generational acumen for spotting opportunities, it is also a window to the community’s culture and heritage.

(Clockwise from below) A tray of freshly baked bread and kahwa; Pahalgam by the river Lidder; tourists on sleds; goats that double up as photo ops; and wazwan being cooked. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

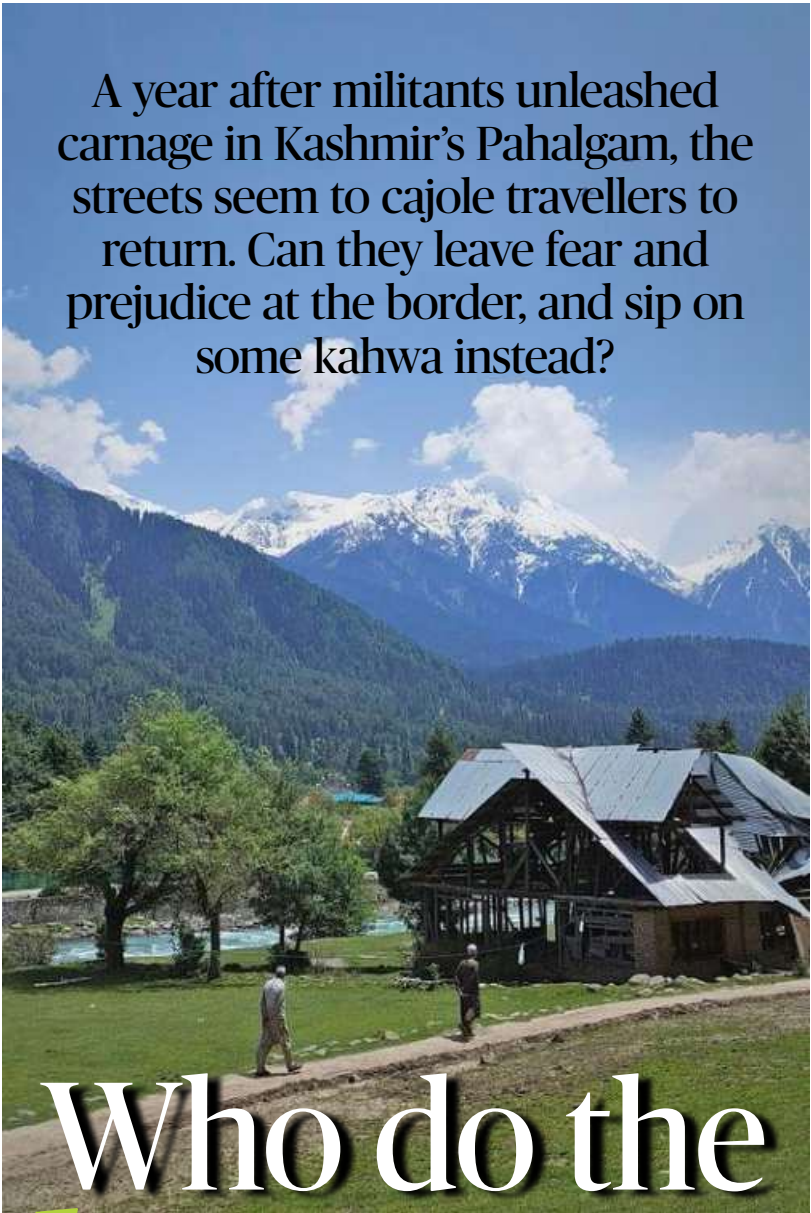


Sanjana Ganesh
sanjana.g@thehindu.co.in

In a good day, when traffic does not clog Jammu and Kashmir's roads and highways; or if travelling is not impaired by the movement of security forces, Pahalgam takes two and a half hours from Srinagar, says Aishaq Hassan, our driver. "Stare out the window. I will play you my list of old Hindi songs even if you do not understand it," he says, already assuming the familiar role of a host. As we leave the summer capital's polluted streets behind, the roads begin resembling poet Agha Shahid Ali's *Postcard from Kashmir*. The lines from my Class VI text book: "This is home. And this the closest I'll ever be to home. When I return, the colours won't be so brilliant, the Jhelum's waters so clean, so ultramarine. My love so overexposed," echo out of the blue. My lungs adjust to the crisp air from the sturdy grey mountains speckled with snow. There are acres of apple trees, and chinars with trunks thick as walls. "I'm a poet too, you know," Aishaq says, prattling off lines in Urdu that sound like dense couplets. I nod the 'super' sign to him. "Leave it, you won't understand," he says, and then stops where the river Lidder appears. "We are getting close," he adds.

Follow the mule

To get to Pahalgam by road, tourists must pass through Pampore, where purple saffron blooms between October and November; and through Sangam, where stacks of willow mimic chic hutments. If you are lucky, someone like Aishaq will insist that you drink kahwa laden with powdered



Who do the heavens beckon?

almonds from Pampore because the saffron is best there – fresh red stigma that turns a rich orange-yellow with water. Your luck is not likely to run dry in Kashmir as a tourist though. Every turn is a journey, every bend, a stream of thought, and otherwise. "There is a grave misconception about Kashmir," says Nazir Ahmed, resident manager, Pine and Peak, a property of Welcomhotel By ITC Hotels in Pahalgam. One year ago, Nazir was one of several hundred locals from Pahalgam sheltering stranded tourists with no way out of the town after a terror attack. On April 21, 2025, militants unleashed brutal violence in the region's picturesque Baisaran valley, full of rolling green meadows, killing 26

tourists. Videos from the incident, were played over and over by Indian news channels with a barrage of exaggerated animations. "We heard shots sometime in the afternoon coming from somewhere uphill. Baisaran is only a six-kilometre trek from the property. We instantly knew it was firing. We are familiar with the sound of bullets. My boss called the police station. That is when we knew that it was something major. Us drivers went rushing to Baisaran but also to Pahalgam's top A-B-C tourist spots – Aru, Betaab, and Chandanwadi valleys – to gather everyone. It was a horrific day that I hope we never relive," says Jahangeer Ahmad Shah, a driver. Except when the entire valley was



shut down during the height of militancy in the 1990s and early 2000s, Pahalgam was always considered safe. For years now, the destination has been viewed as an essential part of the Kashmir itinerary. A definite day-trip to the tourist spots where able-bodied people are transported on comical looking coloured sleds, and goats are made to wear sunglasses and pompoms, is guaranteed. My job as a journalist is to use words to describe people, places, and things. But I find myself scrambling for words to describe Pahalgam. I wish I could play you the sound recording of a whistling thrush singing as water flows through rocks and crevices in the Lidder's path. The hill station, full of trees, takes on a most beautiful serenity. Life here is meant to be lived in a slow, sensible manner. Words can take time. Sometimes even years, to get right. In the last year though, Pahalgam's main markets, once overrun by tourists especially during peak season all the way from April to December, were used for playing cricket, says Muzaffer Raina, a caddy at Lidder valley golf course. While sitting on perfectly

manicured grass amidst dandelion flowers that look frail, Muzaffer says that it is a heartening sign to see A-B-C fill up again this summer. While Baisaran valley and a number of treks from the region have been disallowed due to security reasons, tourists from across the country seem to be flocking the region, getting their share of 'Pahadi Maggi', even though it was never really a thing in Kashmir until after the pandemic. "Things are looking up for us but not entirely yet. Pahalgam survives on tourism. The hope is for things to settle quickly," he says. Over an elaborate wazwan, a thali of many different mutton dishes including rogan josh, and delicious fresh saag, Nazir Ahmad says that occupancy is currently 60% in hotels across the valley. This is a good sign, especially because it means that more people are staying at the destination rather than considering it a day trip. Javed Burza, president, Pahalgam Hotels and Owners Association (PHOA), agrees, adding that the price of rooms in hotels at Pahalgam range from ₹1,000 to ₹30,000 a night, based on the requirement of various customers. "Things may be looking up but prejudice is yet to

change," he says. Shabir Malik, a pony rider and tour guide, says that although the pony riders were the first to aid with rescue before the Army arrived, the discrimination against them has been indiscriminate. For six months after the incident, they had to present themselves at Pahalgam's police station twice a day. "One customer told me three times 'You're going to take me somewhere and shoot me'. What can you do when this is someone's sense of humour. All I am here to do is my job," Shabir says. It is why places like Pine and Peak are packaging experiences where one meets locals, samples cuisine from the region, and picnics in spots only known to those who share secrets with trees. "All we can hope for after this, is the best," Nazir says. At Betab Valley, I meet a young veterinary student from Mumbai who is pouting for photos with her two friends. Behind her are the mountains resplendent with snow. She speaks for 15 minutes and then asks me to not quote her by name. "My friends were joking that I was going to be shot. Just to be prepared, I asked my Muslim friends to teach me some verses of the Quran. Upon coming here though, I must admit that every Kashmiri has been nothing but friendly. It has made me resist the idea of an 'us' and 'them'," she says. In a valley mired by multiplicities – self-determination, Internet shutdowns, magical mountains, cashmere, and tandoors of freshly baked bread – Kashmir succeeds in its kindness. An evidently reductionist take but advice for you nevertheless: Leave prejudice at the door and sip on some kahwa instead. The heavens after all beckon the kind.

This writer was in Pahalgam at the invitation of Welcome by ITC Pine and Peak

Freshly brewed jazz

Begin your Saturday with a morning of classical jazz, bossa nova and regional tunes, best enjoyed amidst the aroma of freshly brewed coffee. Chennai-based singer Ranjani will be joined by her longtime collaborator and guitarist Vikram Vivekanand for an intimate set, featuring her signature, high energy music and eclectic choices. Having given performances for over 20 years now, Ranjani's musical journey includes performing with her all-girl rock band Mantra, and collaborations with musicians like IndoSoul and Blues Conscience. @ Kat & Kin Coffee Roasters, Neelankarai, from 11am onwards on June 6. Tickets from ₹499 onwards on BookMyShow.



Sunday brunch on a loop

At Chennai speakeasy Mad Co, get ready to experience the Modern Indian pop-up. The menu, curated by Chef Mathangi Kumar will be available à la carte through the day alongside the restaurant's regular offerings on demand with a few exceptions. Look out for muntha masala with vethalai crisps and kari por, molagha mandi stuffed mirchi fritter with tamarind vinaigrette, umami wings with ullavacharu and stracciatella, techa paneer with sarso ka saag, mutton kachuri with more kuzhambhi and green apple slaw, coconut prawns with Byadgi chilli and coconut curry, and more. The Sunday brunch will be set alongside a live performance by Troyden Netto, the only live-looping artiste in South India. The electro-acoustic set blends vocals, guitar, keyboards, harmonica, percussion and beatboxing, layered in real time through live looping. The menu is available today and tomorrow from noon to 5pm. Seating is limited. For reservations, connect on Instagram @madco_chennai. A meal for two costs roughly ₹4,000.



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MRP ₹440 Onwards
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Loose Sugar Small
1 kg

₹44.50

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Loose Urad Washed
Gota 1 kg

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Market Price ₹144



Classic Krishna Idly
Rice 10 kg

₹375

MRP ₹800 | SAVE ₹425



Heera Moti Whole
Wheat Atta 5 kg

₹189

MRP ₹290 | SAVE ₹101



₹41.50
/kg

SMART Price

₹1079

SAVE ₹921

Krishna Boiled Rice 26 kg

MRP ₹2000

Be - Rite Refined
Sunflower Oil 1 L

₹164

MRP ₹185 | SAVE ₹21



Mr Gold Filtered Ground
Nut Oil 1 L

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Aachi / Sakthi / Meiyal /
L.G. Spices (Select Range)

BUY ANY 2
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(Select Variants)

FLAT 33%
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MRP ₹265 Onwards
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Soap 125 g Onwards (Multi Pack)
(Select Variants)

SAVE ₹125

MRP ₹379 Onwards
SMART Price ₹254 Onwards



Stayfree / Whisper Sanitary Pads
40 Pieces (Select Variants)

FLAT 50%
OFF

MRP ₹330 Onwards
SMART Price ₹165 Onwards



My Home Toilet / Floor Cleaner 1 L
(1 + 1 Kitted Pack) (Select Variants)

₹149

MRP ₹209 Onwards | SAVE ₹60 Onwards



Shampoo
580 ml Onwards
(Select Variants)

FLAT 60%
OFF

MRP ₹800 Onwards | SMART Price ₹320 Onwards



Ariel / Surf Excel Matic
Liquid Detergent 4 kg
(Select Variants)

SAVE ₹230

MRP ₹765 Onwards | SMART Price ₹535 Onwards



Milky Mist Cow
Ghee 1 L

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MRP ₹930 | SAVE ₹255



Sunfeast Yippee! Magic Masala
Noodles 420 g

SAVE ₹30

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SMART Price ₹305 Onwards



Sprite / Thums Up / Coca-Cola /
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BUY ANY 3
GET ANY 1
FREE

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Note Book

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GET 1
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MINIMUM
5%
BELOW
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EVERYDAY

SUGAR
1 kg
₹9
EVERYDAY
*ON SHOPPING OF
₹2499 & ABOVE

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Mandapam, MADHAVARAM - Behind Madhavaram Circle Bus Stop, MANAPAKKAM - Near by L&T Back Gate,
MARAIMALAI NAGAR - Maraimalai Nagar Industrial Complex, MOGAPPAIR - Bharathi Salai, Phase -2,
Nolambur, NAVALUR - Vivira Mall, PALAVAKKAM - East Coast Road, PERAMBUR - M.P.M Road, ROYAPETTAH -
Express Avenue Mall, VADAPALANI - Near AVM Studio, VELACHERY - Phoenix Market City, VELLORE - Near
Lakshmi Theatre. GUDUVANCHERY - GST Road, NPR Kalyana Mandapam, Opp. EB Office, PADUR - Rajiv
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Malayalam

Least effective film of the franchise



SR Praveen
praveen.sr@thehindu.co.in

Georgekutty, the protagonist of the *Drishyam* franchise, has the kind of baggage that perhaps few other onscreen criminals have carried. He is no natural criminal. Rather, his criminality is built upon his image of a complete family man, someone who goes to any lengths to protect his family.

In *Drishyam 3*, writer-director Jeethu Joseph firmly places him in family situations for much of the runtime. Georgekutty (Mohanlal) is busy arranging the marriage of his elder daughter, Anju (Ansiba Hassan). Brokers come and go, and promising proposals fall through, with the family’s dark past remaining as a barrier to many. Some anonymous souls in the neighbourhood are also trying to spoil the marriage plans. The marriage itself is integral to the plot development. So much so that the film could have come with the tagline – The Story of an Arranged Marriage.

Jeethu appears to be steering away from expectations associated with the *Drishyam* franchise, choosing to expand further on how a criminal act changes the lives of all those connected with it rather than serving the audience with mind-numbing twists. Georgekutty might have had the last laugh in the first part, but in both sequels, he is constantly worried about the price that his family will have to pay for the act, even though he is courageous enough to have produced a movie based on the real-life incident. The question of whether the police will reopen the cold case again is on the minds of all the principal players.

Drishyam 3 delves deep into Georgekutty’s character to see how life’s vicissitudes have taken a toll on him and those around him. One interesting tangent is that Georgekutty is unaware of the struggles of those who aided him in times of trouble. Missteps are galore, too. Especially how one popular antagonist resurfaces with a comical red eye, although the actor’s performance somehow makes up for it. A seemingly important journalist character (Veena Nandakumar) is introduced and forgotten halfway through. Much of the film is dragged down by the heavy-handed drama and dialogue. Adding to the problems is the dated visual style.

What could have turned into a complete disaster is saved by a few intriguing flourishes in the writing and by Mohanlal’s interpretation of Georgekutty’s mindscape. *Drishyam 3*, the least effective of the three films, does not feel like a page from a thriller series, but rather a peek into the personal diary of someone who has not had a peaceful day in years. But then, there is only so much excitement that can be built from a diary entry. May D3 be the last entry, although the makers teased the possibility of one more in the epilogue.

Drishyam 3 is currently running in theatres.

A split verdict

Hindi

Anuj Kumar
anuj.kumar@thehindu.co.in

Another week, another commentary on uncomfortable societal truths packaged in the form of a mystery where solid performances and subtext are marred by predictable beats. At first glance, Ashwiny Iyer Tiwari’s *System* masquerades as a legal thriller, but beneath its polished exterior, it promises to lay bare the facade of institutional neutrality. It positions the courtroom not as a temple of justice, but as a theatre of social stratification where truth is a manufactured commodity.

Neha Rajvansh (Sonakshi Sinha), a public prosecutor fighting the suffocating shadow of her iconic legal patriarch (Ashutosh Gowariker), is subtly challenged from the margins by Sarika (Jyotika), a humble yet resilient stenographer who weaponises the very



bureaucratic machinery designed to keep her invisible.

It is formatted as a chess match of power, legacy, and the heavy price of institutional compliance, but by the midway point, the moves lose their edge, and the loops become easy to read.

Sonakshi captures the vulnerability of a professional who realises that the very apparatus she champions is inherently flawed. Her performance successfully highlights Neha’s internal conflict as she

struggles to reconcile her ethical duty with her elite status.

Jyotika gets an opportunity to lean into a moral grey area as the underpaid, overlooked but astutely observant stenographer who has spent decades sitting at the literal feet of the powerful, and she delivers a performance rooted in absolute economy of movement. However, instead of blending into the background like an invisible cog in the legal system, Jyotika carries a distinct, sharp, and sophisticated

gravitas, creating a slight disconnect with her character’s arc as the film progresses.

Ravi Rajvansh is written as an elite patriarchal father trope common in legal and corporate dramas. Gowariker’s performance saves the character from being a flat caricature, but Ravi’s motivations are highly predictable. When he asks his daughter to win ten consecutive cases before joining his firm, it promises an interesting take on nepotism, but the storytelling reduces the gatekeeping to a formulaic numbers game, built solely to give the protagonist a hurdle.

Moreover, condensing the parallel tracks of Sarika and Neha, which coalesce into a potent sisterhood against the compromised patriarchal system, into a tight cinematic runtime results in rushed, convenient resolutions that weaken the film’s depth.

After the setup draws you in, one can see an imbalance between the narrative’s thematic intent and emotional execution. As we have seen in several recent OTT films, when a viewer can spot a character’s

long-term strategy from a distance, the narrative stops being a mystery and becomes a predictable checklist of talking points. For a legal thriller to land its punches, the audience needs to experience the tension of uncertainty. Gradually, the dynamic between Sarika and Neha makes

System

Director: Ashwiny Iyer Tiwari

Cast: Sonakshi Sinha, Jyotika, Ashutosh Gowariker, Vijayant Kohli, Adinath Kothare

Storyline: An ambitious prosecutor teams up with a resilient court stenographer to fight for justice after a high-profile influencer is murdered. However, their legal crusade takes a deeply personal turn when they find themselves pitted against the prosecutor’s powerful father.

Neha look less like a privileged lawyer with a blind spot and more like a simple plot device to move Sarika’s plans forward. It dilutes the credibility of both leads.

As a director trading in tangible characters and spaces, Ashwiny overcorrects by adopting high-gloss streaming aesthetics. As a result, her world begins to feel like a meticulously curated gallery rather than a breathing, chaotic legal landscape of Delhi. By sanitising these environments into neatly composed, colour-coordinated frames, the art direction inadvertently strips away the organic texture of the space.

No doubt, the point *System* raises that power defines truth is important and timely, but the movie doesn’t fully give its intellectual intent an emotional shape. When Sarika tells Neha that ‘justice is difficult to find like God’, she might as well be talking about the film’s missing narrative balance.

System is currently streaming on Amazon Prime Video



An agonisingly poignant romance

Writer-director Vivek Soni balances real-world accountability with the traditional, sweeping magic of young romance.

Hindi

Anuj Kumar
anuj.kumar@thehindu.co.in

At a time when mainstream romance usually oscillates between airbrushed fantasy and comedy, with a dash of toxic masculinity, Vivek Soni’s *Chand Mera Dil* arrives as a grounded, mature counter-narrative. It subverts the grammar of a Bollywood musical melodrama, or what we call the Dharma production tropes, to deliver a sharp dissection of modern intimacy with a melancholic flourish.

After a long time, a love story doesn’t dump career and bread and butter issues. Aarav (Lakshya) and Chandni (Ananya Panday) are not flaky cardboards. Besides the raging hormones, they come across as believable Engineering students facing rigorous academic pressures. They do not drop out when life gets messy. The writing (Vivek, Tushar Paranjpe, and Akshat Ghildiyal) respects their intellect and ambition, showing that pursuing career ambitions isn’t an alternative to a love story, or vice versa. It is a heavy framework within which the love story must exist, and Ananya Panday and Lakshya strike a delicate equilibrium to anchor the film’s transition from a lyrical college romance into a stark, mature reality. They establish an effortless physical and emotional intimacy early on, making the eventual fracture sting all the more.

There is hardly any external conflict. There are no mother or memory issues or class barriers threatening their union. Instead, the narrative hinges on a sudden crisis within their own ecosystem. An

Chand Mera Dil

Director: Vivek Soni

Cast: Ananya Panday, Lakshya, Paresh Pahuja, Manish Chaudhuri, Pratham Rathod, Irawati Harshe

Synopsis: A passionate college romance between Engineering students Aarav and Chandni turns messy when an unplanned pregnancy forces them into early marriage and adulthood.



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unplanned pregnancy compounded by pressures of career and making ends meet builds into frustration and a violent outburst by Aarav, which pulls them apart.

Unlike Bollywood tropes where the heroine compromises her identity to preserve love, the film positions self-respect as an uncompromising boundary for the modern woman. Early in the film, when the couple explicitly labels their bond as legendary, one doesn’t take it seriously. But when Chandni’s decision to move out turns out to be her willingness to kill that exact illusion, it strikes. By taking complete ownership of the pregnancy, Chandni quietly strips Aarav of his saviour complex. Vivek gives her a believable backstory about growing up in a fractured family. She has raised herself. It defines her arc where she refuses to engage in cyclical, toxic shouting matches. She looks for safety, and an office colleague looks like a safe harbour.

At the same time, your heart is forced to beat for Aarav because he isn’t a situationship partner who kept one foot out of the door. He was all-in. Vivek handles Aarav with empathy, ensuring the audience feels the tragic weight of his loss as sharply as Chandni’s choice. Her resistance constantly raises a question: Is she overreacting, or is she retreating because the foundational trust has collapsed? It can divide the audience, but without weaning them out of the story. This makes the second act an agonisingly beautiful watch.

Shot on location in Hyderabad, the film gives a fresh vibe with textured, authentic campus settings.

The visual grammar leans heavily into warm but melancholic colour tones, focusing on shadows, close-ups of shared glances, and physical distance in the frame to emphasise both emotional

yearning and alienation. The music and lyrics (Sachin-jigar and Amitabh Bhattacharya) mirror the protagonists’ psychological state and form the emotional spine of the regret-filled romance.

Both Ananya and Lakshya come across as regular students in a realistic college ambience with a fresh set of friends. Lakshya does the heavy lifting in the difficult role of a boy who is forced to mature early. Chequered by the frustration and insecurity of being unable to build a career because of a romantic commitment, the actor captures the agony of a young Indian boy who is unprepared for responsibility and evolves into a broken soul, trapped under the weight of his own guilt and resentment. For Ananya, the film marks a decisive break from the glossy, hyper-stylised mould, and she breathes life into Chandni. The heavy pauses mid-sentence and a fixed, glassy stare that capture a spirit checking out of a relationship– she comes across as an unyielding wall against the frenetic energy of Lakshya.

There are moments when the script feels a little too clearly structured into segments with clear tonal shifts. You know, the information that could have been shared in the romance phase is deliberately held for the time when life unravels. There are small passages where characters start explaining the subtext to the audience, but eventually *Chand Mera Dil* proves that the romance doesn’t lose its magic when it encounters real life. A love story works when you start caring for both protagonists and want to see them together. *Chand Mera Dil* evokes that rare feeling as it mines the relatable grey areas of modern relationships.

Chand Mera Dil is currently running in theatres.

Jack Ryan:
Ghost War

Director: Andrew Bernstein

Cast: John Krasinski, Wendell Pierce, Michael Kelly, Max Beesley, JJ Field, Douglas Hodge, Betty Gabriel, Sienna Miller

Storyline: Jack Ryan is pulled out of civilian life to uncover yet another can of worms in the intelligence world



John Krasinski
cannot save this

English

Mini Anthikad Chhibber

mini.chhibber@thehindu.co.in

At the end of the fourth and final season of the political thriller, *Jack Ryan* (2018- 2023), based on Tom Clancy’s characters, Ryan (John Krasinski) saved the world again, left the CIA and walked into the sunset with his girlfriend, Cathy. Alas, there is no rest for the wicked and studio heads will not let a winning franchise go quietly into the night. And so we have *Jack Ryan: Ghost War*, a perfectly serviceable little thriller, though not a

particularly great one. The film opens with the mandatory action-packed sequence, this time in Dubai. Orders are barked out, and good men are betrayed amid flying bullets and masonry. Ryan is now a civilian working on Wall Street, jogging peacefully, when he is stopped by James Greer (Wendell Pierce), the Deputy Director of the CIA. Much as Ryan protests, he is a civilian and wants no part of whatever Greer is suggesting, he agrees to meet a man in Dubai, since he is going there anyway for work. Former Venezuela station chief and now CIA contractor, Mike November (Michael Kelly) is going along as backup. Things naturally go very wrong when Ryan manages

to meet the MI6 agent, Nigel Cooke (Douglas Hodge), whose operation was shot to pieces in the opening sequence. This particular can of worms that Ryan uncovers involves rogue MI6 agents, black ops, Greer’s hand in a death by torture, old sins casting long shadows, and Madonna’s *Blond Ambition*. With Krasinski contributing to the story and screenplay, one cannot accuse him of being uninvolved. However, while the film is short, does some glitzy location work (Dubai, the UK), has the requisite action sequences with screeching tyres and shattering glass, it still remains only mildly engaging. The acting is solid, with Krasinski continuing his steady interpretation of Ryan, Pierce providing the gravitas, Kelly the humour, and Max Beesley, as the rogue agent, bringing the danger.

Dubai by night looks like a glittering oasis of light, while jolly England is cute, cosy and green except when bullets are flying or a fleet of black SUVs are thundering by (how they manage this in crowded London is an eternal mystery). Sienna Miller plays MI6 officer Emma Marlow, and a possible love interest for Ryan, as Cathy is nowhere on the scene. The film ends with Greer recommending Ryan for the post of Deputy Director of the CIA, which in Clancy’s *Ryanverse* is canon. As a placeholder, or transition from series to movie format, *Jack Ryan: Ghost War* is serviceable. One cannot be blamed for wanting more considering the original Ryan movies starred Harrison Ford and were directed by Phillip Noyce.

Jack Ryan: Ghost War is currently streaming on Amazon Prime Video

Snippets



Rajkummar Rao and Keerthy Suresh’s
Raftaar gets new release date

Rajkummar Rao and Keerthy Suresh’s upcoming film, *Raftaar* is delayed. The film, which was earlier set to be released on July 24, will now hit the screens on October 16, the makers announced on May 22. As per the makers, “The film is set in the cut-throat world of India’s booming ed-tech industry, *Raftaar* races through the meteoric rise of a start-up and a fiery relationship at its core—a determined man and an ambitious woman chasing success at any cost.” Directed by Aditya Nimbalkar, written by Rohan Narula, *Raftaar* also stars Anurag Thakur, Rohan Verma, Tanya Maniktala, and Rajat Kapoor in pivotal roles. It is produced by Patralekhaa under Kampa Films.



Saiyami Kher to play a photographer
in Vikram Phadnis’ next

Actor Saiyami Kher will be seen playing a photographer in fashion designer and director Vikram Phadnis’ upcoming film. The actor’s team shared her first look from the film with the press. In the first look, she’s holding a professional camera amidst a natural outdoor backdrop. As per a press release, Saiyami took inspiration from her real life friend, fashion photographer, Taras Taraporvala for her role in the film. The currently untitled film also stars Tahir Raj Bhasin, Vineet Kumar Singh in pivotal roles. More details from it are awaited. Saiyami was last seen in Sunny Deol’s *Jaat* (2025).



Mega 158: Chiranjeevi’s film with
Bobby Kolli goes on floor

Telugu superstar Chiranjeevi’s upcoming movie with Bobby Kolli has gone on floors, the makers announced on May 21. The movie, tentatively titled *Mega 158*, is produced by KVN Productions of *Jana Nayagan* and *Toxic* fame. Andhra Pradesh Deputy Chief Minister and Telugu superstar Pawan Kalyan graced the launch of the event. The actor clapped the board to signal the film’s beginning during a pooja ceremony at the Annapurna Studios in Hyderabad on May 21. Malayalam actor Anaswara Rajan, who is set to play a prominent character in the movie, also graced the occasion. Vijay Karthik Kannan of *Jailer* fame is the cinematographer.



This might not be the way

The Mandalorian and Grogu leaves us wishing Jon Favreau had pushed the envelope a little further beyond a bunch of quests for Baby Yoda’s big screen debut

English

Mini Anthikad Chhibber

mini.chhibber@thehindu.co.in

When the countdown used images from *The Mandalorian* to end with “forged for IMAX”, one was all set for high adventure in a galaxy far, far away. In place of the opening crawl, we have a couple of title cards for those who came in late, like in the Phantom comics, and then we are off to a James Bond-style opener. Din Djarin (Pedro Pascal), a Mandalorian bounty hunter, and his war Grogu, work for the New Republic, hunting Imperial warlords across the galaxy. After successfully completing a mission, replete with hulking AT-ATs smartly dispatched into snowy crevices, Din and Grogu head to the New Republic base, where Colonel Ward (Sigourney Weaver) gives Din his new assignment. The crime lord Jabba the Hutt’s son,

Star Wars:
The
Mandalorian
and Grogu

Director: Jon Favreau

Starring: Pedro Pascal, Jeremy Allen White, Brendan Wayne, Lateef Crowder, Sigourney Weaver

Storyline: The New Republic tasks Mandalorian and Grogu with rescuing Jabba the Hutt’s son in exchange for information on the warlord Coin. However, the facts play out very differently on the ground

Rotto (Jeremy Allen White), has been kidnapped. Jabba’s twin cousins, who are running his empire after his death, have information about the warlord Coin and are willing to reveal his location when Rotto is returned to them. Din is not too keen on the task but goes anyway, meeting the twins before heading to the planet Shakari, where Rotto is supposed to be. Din finds Rotto... and a different truth. Many gladiatorial combats, gross and glorious creatures later, all is well that ends well, with the New Republic squadrons flying in and all sorts of mansions and hidey holes exploding with satisfying bangs and blasts of fire. A continuation of *The Mandalorian*, which ran for three seasons from 2019 to 2023, *The Mandalorian and Grogu* suffers from the same problems that plagued the later seasons of the show, where Din just seemed to be going from point A to B, doing things. Whenever the narrative flagged, Grogu would step in to do something impossibly cute. So while there is some nifty action, and touching sequences of Grogu caring for Din, slimily wonderful creatures (oooooh that dragonsnake!) surprisingly flat visual effects and Martin Scorsese is a hoot as

the Ardenian shopkeeper, Hugo, whom Din approaches for information on Rotto, *The Mandalorian and Grogu* feels underwhelming. This cannot be the Star Wars reboot Dave Filoni, President and Chief Creative Officer (CCO) of Lucasfilm, who shares writing credit with Favreau, could have been aiming for. *The Mandalorian and Grogu* feels like a bunch of episodes of Season 4 strung together to Ludwig Göransson’s lush musical score. There are quests and journeys, helpers and hinderers, weird and wonderful creatures, shiny spaceships and buckets of bolts jumping into hyperspace. Just like *The Mandalorian* came at a time when the world had turned on its head thanks to an evil virus, the little green guy’s first screen outing comes at a time when the world feels even more off-kilter. So you could forget about real-life bombings and online trolls to lose yourself in Grogu’s big ears and coos, but do not expect a life-changing movie experience.

Star Wars: The Mandalorian and Grogu is currently running in theatres